

²1966 figures from Malawi Census 1966; 1968 figures from a house-to-house census carried out by G. H. Chikwapulo, Chancellor College.

The repercussions of a recession of Chilwa waters, and consequently of fishing, are even wider. The whole of the Chilwa plain and lake must be seen as an economic network. Not only are there the links between fishing and various other services outlined above, but also those between fishing and farming. Investigation has shown that there is a complementary flow of income between fishing and farming activities. The more successful fishermen have larger gardens and more cash crops than other fishermen. The major cash crop in the south is tobacco, with some tobacco, vegetables, and grains. On the western shore are two rice-growing schemes: one run by the Taiwanese and the other by the Malawi government. Both are in process of expansion.

With the return of the lake waters in 1969 came a renewal of activity in the whole area. Between then and 1971 new stores, canteens, and bars have been built. Not only are the temporary houses up but so are some more permanent buildings in certain parts of the lake. Motorised ferry boats are once again in operation as well as the usual brisk trade in ferrying by canoe. A few fishermen have new fishing boats. Before the recession of the lake, a few fishermen already had motorised boats but these were either sold or unmaintained and left to deteriorate when the income from fishing dried up.

Although this movement of people is made up mainly of fishermen, it includes people providing various services either directly or indirectly to fishing. These include the labourers and other workers employed by fishermen, the large body of fish traders; craftsmen specialising in making canoes, traps, twine, and so on; owners of stores, canteens, and bars; owners of fishing houses; wandering peddlers of small items such as medicines; women and beer sellers; and the people providing ferry services, whether by canoe or large motorised craft.

Because of this migration, the total number of fishermen is an estimate which varies according to sources. Thus, Chipeta (1968) gives a figure of 1,200 fishermen in 1966 while Mzumara notes 5,000 fishermen, of whom 2,000 were in the marshes. Agnew (1970) quotes the Malawi Census figure of 6,444 (which included women and children as well as fishermen and ancillary labour) but also adds the figure of 2,000 fishermen in the northern marshes, which would bring the total to 8,444. The migration caused by the changing levels of the lake is seen clearly in the figures quoted by Agnew (1970), illustrating the effect of the drastic recession of 1967-68. On Nchisi Island, just off the coast, there were 2,015 people in 1966 and only 779 in 1968; at Kachulu Harbour, the main outlet on the west coast at the head of the only all-weather road to the lake, there were 800 people in 1966 and 186 in 1968.²